

INTL 511/601: International Relations Theory Midterm Exam

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Section 1: Short Answer Questions (20%)

1. Realism in Donnelly: "According to Jack Donnelly's discussion of Realism, how does Kenneth Waltz's structural realism differ from classical realism?"

Jack Donnelly, in his discussion on Realism, emphasizes that classical realism and Kenneth Waltz's structural realism are markedly different. Waltz's structural realism emphasizes that in order to understand the behavior of states, it is necessary to focus on the international system rather than the internal characteristics of states. Waltz tries to abstract states without taking into account any of their characteristics other than just their capacities, and in this way emphasizes the effects of anarchy and the distribution of capacities (Donnelly, 2005 p. 35). This approach is different from classical realism's attempt to Decouple between human nature and international anarchy. Classical realism emphasizes the selfish and competitive aspects of human nature, while structural realism decries such intrinsic motivations and argues that the structural pressures of the system shape the behavior of states.

Classical realism emphasizes the immutable characteristics of human nature, while Structural realism draws attention to the quest of states for survival and the balance of power. Structural realism, assuming the survival motive of states, argues that the anarchic structure of the international system forces states to balance. This is different from classical realism's emphasis on how selfish and competitive aspects of human nature fuel international conflicts. Donnelly made this situation even more understandable by giving the example of the Cold War. According to Donnelly, no one

caused the Cold War, it was a natural consequence of bipolarity (Donnelly, 2005 p. 36). So it was a search for a balance.

In conclusion, in Donnelly's discussion, Waltz's structural realism focuses on permanent structural pressures in international relations, while classical realism focuses more on the role of human nature and the intrinsic motivations of states in international politics. This indicates that structural realism offers a more abstract and systemic approach that emphasizes the structural features of the international system.

2. Liberal Internationalism: "What are the core tenets of Liberal Internationalism post-Cold War, as outlined by [Burchill](#)?"

Scott Burchill summarizes Liberal Internationalism in the post-Cold War period with a few basic principles. Firstly, the spread of liberal democracies is seen as a prerequisite for the end of international conflicts. This view is based on Kant's idea of a "peaceful federation" and is related to the ability and willingness of liberal democracies to establish peaceful relations among themselves (Burchill, p. 59-60).

Secondly, economic integration and free trade are considered important elements that promote international cooperation and increase interdependence between states. This is especially embodied by examples of regional economic integration, such as the European Union, and allows states that have historically experienced deconfliction to come together within the framework of economic and political cooperation. In explaining this issue, Burchill draws attention to eighteenth- and nineteenth-century liberals, saying that they considered the spirits of war and commerce to be mutually incompatible. The states have engaged in many wars to achieve their mercantilist goals. He states that it was not to promote the well-being of society and its members but to increase the power of the state, of which the sovereign is the embodiment.

(Burchill, p. 63-64). The situation that this can be overcome with economic integration and cooperation based on a liberal basis is put forward.

Thirdly, the protection and dissemination of human rights is another cornerstone of liberal internationalism. Burchill makes an introduction to the spread of human rights as follows: The defense of democracy and free trade is a harbinger of another idea that liberal internationalism has brought to international theory and prepares the ground for it. This is the development and defense of human rights. Liberal thought argues that the legitimacy of the internal order of states depends on the rule of law and their respect for the human rights of their citizens.

And finally, Burchill draws attention to the issue of the system. Liberal internationalism emphasizes that international institutions and regimes play an important role in increasing deconfliction between states and making the international system more predictable and orderly. This situation encourages states to define their own interests within the framework of broader cooperation and to adapt to international norms.

3. Critical Theory by Linklater: "What role does the 'politics of knowledge' play in shaping IR according to Linklater?"

While Linklater explains the purpose of the concept of politics of knowledge, the politics of knowledge, explains it by arguing that approaches to understanding the social world are not objective, but rather are shaped by specific political interests and goals. In this context, the politics of knowledge determines which information is considered important in IR and which perspectives are prioritized (Linklater, 2007 p. 54-55). Linklater also states that the current state of critical theory and whether it has changed should be questioned. This inquiry aims to identify counter-hegemonic

movements that question existing structures and principles. In this context, politics of knowledge is a critical tool for understanding which theories and information have become dominant in IR and which interests they support. For example, neorealism's acceptance of international anarchy as an immutable situation invites people to submit to this situation, while critical theory aims to reveal the ideological influences behind such approaches.

Linklater also examines how the politics of knowledge affects the struggle between hegemonic and counter-hegemonic forces in IR. This struggle involves collective efforts to change the organization of world politics. In this context, critical theory analyzes how information policies are shaped in IR and what social and political interests these policies support. This analysis aims to contribute to the efforts to create a more just and egalitarian world order in IR.

4. Constructivism in Reus-Smit: "According to Reus-Smit, how does anarchy differ based on social interactions and shared norms? Provide a quote from the assigned readings to support your answer."

According to Reus-Smit's understanding of constructivism, anarchy differs within the framework of social interactions and shared norms. Constructivists argue that anarchy is not just a power vacuum, but also a socially constructed concept. This means that the identities and interests of states and other international actors are shaped through social interactions and shared norms. Reus-Smit states that constructivists focus on how normative and ideational structures shape the identities and interests of actors. This shows how the nature of anarchy can be perceived and experienced in different ways by these norms and identities. Reus-Smit, "Normative and ideological structures are seen as shaping actors' identities and interests through three mechanisms: imagination, communication and constraint" (Reus-Smit, 2005 p.

198) explains how these structures shape the identities and interests of actors. These mechanisms determine how actors imagine their actions, what strategies they can think of, and what ethical and practical boundaries they recognize. Therefore, anarchy can be experienced in different ways under the influence of these social and ideational structures. For example, Reus-Smit addresses the relations of Canada and Cuba with the United States, highlighting differences that cannot be explained only by the balance of military power. While Canada is a close ally of the United States, Cuba is seen as an enemy. This difference shows how factors such as identity and ideology create different meanings on the balance of power (Reus-Smit, 2005). In this context, anarchy is structured and experienced in different ways through social interactions and shared norms.

Section 2: Analytical Essays (50%)

Prompt 1: "Compare how Marxism and Critical Theory approach global capitalism. Include arguments from [Griffiths](#), and discuss the influence of global capitalism."

Global capitalism is a system characterized by the worldwide integration of economies through trade, investment and technology, and has become a dominant force shaping societies. Therefore, it is important to decently analyze the relationship between globalization and capitalism, because this connection is of critical importance, especially for the understanding of the concept of global capitalism. Globalization plays a decisive role in the transformation of economic, social and political structures by expanding the basic dynamics of capitalism at the international level. Jan Aart Scholte explains this situation in his article "Global capitalism and the state" as follows: Globalization, while reshaping the functioning of capitalism, has been promoted through elements such as processes of accumulation of surplus value, broader Sunday searches, low-cost labor and regulations, and information technologies. At the same time, globalization has also had a great impact on capitalism; capital has adopted cross-border forms of organization and increased the waves of competition, mergers and acquisitions in the world Sunday. In the conditions of globalized capitalism, the role and character of the state have changed; changes such as the end of the sovereign state, the rise of supranational constituencies, a decrease in interstate warfare, increasing restrictions on social security provision, the growth of multilateralism and the difficulty of ensuring

democratic governance only through the state have occurred (Scholte, 1997).

Scholte's analysis of globalization comprehensively addresses the transformation of capitalism and the state. I think the analysis should be considered as the success of the global west and capitalist countries. It is a really important point to draw attention to how global capitalism is in a more integrated world, the transition of capital and the search for a global Sunday, in relation to the situation of undeveloped and developing states. Because it must be clarified how globalization accelerates the accumulation of surplus value and deepens the exploitation of the working class in this process. Globalization can weaken workers' rights and make labor power even more precarious by increasing the cross-border mobility of capital. Resorting to the analyses of Marxist Theory to explain this situation provides an important insight. It would be a mistake to approach Global Capitalism only in the context of economic fundamentals. Because, focusing on the cultural and ideological dimensions of globalization and questioning how these processes reproduce social inequalities is an important detail. At this point, applying the arguments of critical theory can provide different perspectives. Martin Griffiths explains this situation as follows. The main issue for Marxists is the injustice of global capitalism and the stratification of class on a global scale. For critical theorists, this is unnecessary suffering caused not only by capitalism, but also by other dynamics of modernity at the global level (Griffiths, 2007) As Griffiths emphasizes, Marxist and Critical Theory perspectives are critical to understanding the complex structure of global capitalism. While Marxists criticize the injustice of global capitalism and class stratification, Critical Theory argues that other dynamics of modernity also contribute to these injustices. Globalization deepens social inequalities not only through economic, but also cultural and ideological processes. In this context, taking into account both the economic and

cultural dimensions while evaluating the effects of global capitalism allows us to develop a more holistic understanding.

At this point, I think that it is appropriate to use the arguments of Ian Bruff's article on the globalization debate here. I think that he has very valid determinations, especially from the Marxist point of view and from the Neo-Gramscian point of view. Bruff mentions three wave models to explain globalization in his article and emphasizes that the most ideal approach is the synthesis of the third wave and the Neo-Gramscian approach. I think the third wave is Critical theory. In short, I would like to explain the three waves and finally analyze the Marxist approach and the critical approach in the context of this article. The three waves represent different approaches to the globalization debate and each offers different perspectives on the nature and effects of globalization: The first wave argues that globalization severely restricts the movement space of states and forces them to a liberal economic model. He suggests that the end of the nation-state is inevitable and that capital can easily cross borders. However, he is criticized for exaggerating the forces of change. The second wave argues that globalization has not completely eliminated the sphere of action of states. It emphasizes that states have the capacity to adapt to new global conditions. However, it is criticized for remaining state-centered and seriously exaggerating state capacity, as well as ignoring international institutions and organizations. The third wave, so critical theory, goes beyond the empirical focuses of the first two waves and questions how globalization is perceived and how it operates throughout time and space. This wave adopts a multi-scale, multidimensional approach to the question of globalization and exhibits an interdisciplinary stance. He argues that globalization is not a single process or dynamic, but rather consists of multiple globalization processes interacting in

specific and probabilistic ways. These processes develop irregularly over time and space, are complex, and often encounter resistance. The third wave proposes that globalization as a discursive structure can have real, causal effects on policy outcomes and the globalization process. However, his epistemological stance can make practical implementation difficult. But critical theory, which does not show a methodological way out and does not center the economic model, cannot provide sufficient foresight in the critique of global capitalism. At this point, Neo-Gramscian theory, which is fed by Marxist literature, has a potential that may allow it to complete the shortcomings of the critical school. This theory sees globalization not only as capitalist expansion, but also as the meanings attributed to this process. Neo-Gramscian theory posits that capitalism is a social order based on unlimited accumulation and therefore recognizes neither spatial nor social boundaries. This perspective suggests that globalization is not a break from the past, but a continuation of the ongoing development of the capitalist organization of production. Neo-Gramscian theory shares many points in common with critical theory literature, arguing that globalization is both a process of capitalist expansion and the meanings attributed to this process. This theory uses concepts such as historical bloc, hegemony and relative autonomy to understand the effects of globalization on national political economies. Neo-Gramscian theory suggests that it may be more important to consider whether people believe in the meanings attributed to globalization, rather than whether globalization itself is a phenomenon (Bruff, 2005) Therefore, the interaction between the literature of critical theory and Neo-Gramscian theory can lead to further innovations in the study of globalization. As a result, both Marxism and Critical Theory provide valuable frameworks for understanding and criticizing global capitalism. While Marxism focuses on economic

exploitation and class struggle, Critical Theory provides insights into the cultural and ideological dimensions of capitalist societies. Because the impact of global capitalism is profound and multifaceted. Economically, it has led to significant inequalities between rich and poor nations and within countries. The promise of prosperity through free markets often results in the concentration of wealth and power, marginalizing many. Culturally, global capitalism promotes a homogenization in which local cultures and identities are eclipsed by a dominant global culture driven by consumerism. This cultural imperialism can erode traditional values and practices. I don't think it's reasonable to expect that an approximation will completely explain global capitalism when all these comprehensive effects are obvious. As Griffiths combines these perspectives, he emphasizes the complexity of global capitalism and the need for a multifaceted critique. As global capitalism continues to shape our world, it is important to explore and develop alternatives that address its economic, cultural and environmental challenges. For this reason, a comprehensive analysis of Neo-Gramscian theory and Critical Theory from Marxist literature allows us to analyze this situation in the best possible way.

Section 3: Simulation Exercise (20%)

Scenario: Analyze a territorial dispute using one IR theory; describe motivations, actions, outcomes. Include relevant quotes from assigned readings to support your analysis.

I will consider this question as Constructivist Theory and the Syrian Civil War. Because Constructivist theory emphasizes the importance of identity, norms and social structures in international relations. This theory argues that the behavior of states and other actors is shaped by their identities and social norms. I think the Syrian Civil War is an example of a complex conflict in which this theory can be applied.

The Syrian Civil War emerged as a result of a series of protests and uprisings that began in 2011 under the influence of the Arab Spring. Anti-government protests began in Daraa, and violence escalated in a short time. The establishment of the Free Syrian Army in July and the armed rebellion began (Ford, 2019) Initially, the protests began with demands for democratic reforms against the authoritarian regime of Syrian President Bashar al-Assad. However, in a short time these protests turned into a large-scale civil war with the influence of sectarian and ethnic conflicts.

Analysis from a Constructivist Perspective:

Constructivist theory focuses on identity politics and social norms to understand the motivations of the Syrian Civil War. Syria is a very ethnically and sectarian diverse country. While the majority of the population consists of Sunni Muslims, the ruling elite usually belongs to the Alawite minority. These sectarian differences can be seen as one of the main motivations for the conflict.

Identity Politics: Sectarian and ethnic identities in Syria have played an important role in the deepening of the conflict. The Alawite minority is seen as one of the main supporters of the Assad regime, while the Sunni majority has been the main source of opposition to the regime. In addition, the Kurdish minority in the country was in an uncomfortable position with the current situation. These identity differences are critical to understanding the motivations of conflict.

Social Norms and Perceptions: Constructivist theory emphasizes how social norms and perceptions are effective in shaping conflict. Historical hostilities and mistrust between different groups in Syria have contributed to the deepening of the Deconfliction. For example, with the establishment of the Syrian Arab Republic in 1961 and the coming to power of the Baath Party in 1963, the Kurdish identity was completely excluded. During this process, the Syrian government began to see the Kurds as a potential security threat (McDowall, 2021, p. 462-464) These social norms have shaped the attitudes and actions of groups towards each other.

Actions and Constructivist Analysis:

Constructivist theory examines how social structures and identities are effective for understanding actions in the Syrian Civil War. Because at different stages of the conflict, various actors acted in accordance with identity politics and social norms.

State and Regime Actions: The Assad regime is not trying to maintain its own power by using its Alawite identity and sectarian allegiances. The regime, with the support of the Alawite community, has taken a harsh stance against the Sunni majority. These actions show how the regime uses identity politics.

Opposition Groups: Opposition groups in Syria are generally united around the Sunni identity. In their struggle against the regime, these groups have tried to expand their

support base by using their sectarian identities and social norms. This situation shows how the actions of the opposition are shaped by identity politics. For example, the Kurds have historically been an important subject of armed struggle with the motivation of exclusion and geographical division by the regime.

International Actors: Constructivist theory argues that international actors also act in accordance with identity politics and social norms. For example, while Iran and Russia supported the Assad regime, countries such as Saudi Arabia and Turkey supported the Sunni opposition. The United States supports Kurdish groups that act secularly in line with regional interests. The actions of these international actors have been shaped in accordance with their own identity policies and regional strategies.

Constructivist Evaluation and conclusion:

Constructivist theory emphasizes the importance of identity politics and social norms for understanding the Syrian Civil War. This theory provides a critical perspective for understanding the motivations, actions and consequences of conflict. The Syrian Civil War is an important example of how identity politics and social norms are effective in international relations. Because the Syrian Civil War has deepened sectarian divisions and increased hostilities between the Alawite and Sunni communities. This case clearly shows how identity politics affects the consequences of conflict. The deconfliction has led to regional instability, increased sectarian tensions in neighboring countries and led to the formation of new alliances between regional powers. In addition, it has led to significant changes in international relations, influenced the attitude of the international community to the intervention in Syria and led to the emergence of new diplomatic dynamics. These developments show how effective social norms and identity politics are at both regional and international levels.

Section 4: Synthesis and Reflection (10%)

Question: "How do Waltz's structural realism and Reus-Smit's Constructivism differ on anarchy? Provide specific references from the readings to support your answer."

Kenneth Waltz's structural realism (neorealism) and Christian Reus-Smit's constructivism address the concept of anarchy in international relations in distinct ways. Waltz, in his structural realism, defines anarchy as the fundamental structural feature of the international system. According to him, anarchy leads states to engage in a constant struggle for power to ensure their security. Donnelly, in his discussion of Waltz's structural realism, emphasizes the impact of anarchy and the distribution of capabilities. He argues that the international structure emerges from the interactions of states and subsequently constrains them, pushing them towards certain actions while deterring others. Despite significant differences in the characteristics and interactions of states, "there is a striking sameness in the quality of international life over a millennium" (Donnelly, 2005, p:35). In this perspective, states are rational actors, and anarchy in the international system is the main factor determining their behavior. Waltz argues that anarchy is an unchanging and fixed structure; therefore, the behavior of states is also a reflection of this structure.

On the other hand, Reus-Smit's constructivism sees anarchy as a socially constructed concept. Constructivists argue that anarchy is shaped by social relations and norms between states. Reus-Smit suggests that anarchy does not have a single meaning, on the contrary, it can be interpreted in different ways in different historical and social contexts. On pages 192-193, where he criticizes neo-realism and neo-liberalism, Reus-Smith says that actors in international relations are not inherently social; they are not products of their social environment, they are atomistic rational beings who establish social relations only to maximize their interests, and states come together in

the cooperative construction and maintenance of functional institutions (Reus-Smit, 2005) This criticism implies that states come together in the collaborative construction and maintenance of functional institutions. This approach supports the constructivist view that the identities and interests of states are shaped through social interactions.

As a result, the main difference between these two approaches is in the explanation of the nature of anarchy. Waltz sees anarchy as an immutable structure, while Reus-Smit argues that anarchy is shaped by social interactions and norms. This difference creates an important distinction in understanding the behavior of states in international relations and the functioning of the system. Waltz's theory offers an analysis focused on power and security, while Reus-Smit's approach emphasizes the role of identities and norms in international politics.

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